Phase 0 · Production document

Episode 1 Script and Text

ផ្នែកបុណ្យ

Every spoken line, recording, journal page, lore note and sketchbook entry in Episode 1, keyed to the beat sheet.

Based on	Episode 1 Beat Sheet v1.0 · Story Bible v1.0
Language	English master · Khmer translation to follow
Version	1.0 · October 2026 · First draft
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01 Conventions and Language

Line IDs	`E1-<beat>-<n>`, for example `E1-A1-03-2`. The beat matches the beat sheet.
Spoken language	All characters speak **Khmer**, recorded by Khmer-speaking actors. The French carriage driver line is the only exception (French-accented Khmer is also acceptable). English and Khmer subtitles.
Written language	In-world documents are written in Khmer (Sok's journal, the deed) or French (official papers). The player reads them in their chosen language; the sketchbook keeps Sora's summary.
Master text	English below is the master for meaning and timing. The Khmer script must be written by a native speaker, not machine-translated, and reviewed by the cultural advisor.
Sora's voice	Sparse. She speaks only when it matters: under her breath, dry, controlled. Most of her thoughts appear in the sketchbook instead.

02 Voices

Character	Lines	Casting notes
Sora	~12	Woman, mid-twenties, Phnom Penh accent. Low, controlled, a little tired; warmth only breaks through at the end.
Yay Mey	~14	Woman in her sixties, Battambang rural accent. Firm and formal, exhausted, grief under strict control.
Vuthy	~10	Man, late twenties, educated town voice; polite, a little stiff, nervous underneath.
Uncle Sok	1 recording	Man in his late forties, hoarse, speaking fast and close to the microphone; recorded with a period gramophone filter.
Carriage driver	2	Older man; frightened, refuses firmly.
The presence	1 word	Layered whisper, processed: a low voice and a grinding, stone-like texture.

03 Dialogue Script

3.1 Prologue

ID	Speaker	Line	Direction
E1-P03-1	**Sora**	…Not tonight, Yay.	*Under her breath, seeing the letters. She takes them anyway.*
E1-P06-1	**Yay Mey**	Sora? Sora, is that you? Child, can you hear me?	*Telephone, heavy static.*
E1-P06-2	**Sora**	Yay? What's wrong? It's past eight—	*Alarmed.*
E1-P06-3	**Yay Mey**	You must come home. Right now. Uncle Sok… he broke it… it's inside the house—	*Breaking up; a screech cuts her off, glass shatters, heavy thuds, dead line.*
E1-P06-4	**Sora**	Yay? …Yay!	*Into the dead line.*

3.2 Act I

ID	Speaker	Line	Direction
E1-A1-01-1	**Driver**	No further, miss. The road is under water. And not to that house, not tonight.	*Rain, horse snorting. Fear, not rudeness.*
E1-A1-01-2	**Sora**	It's all right. I used to know the way.	*Quiet.*
E1-A1-03-1	**Yay Mey**	Sora. Child. You came.	*She takes Sora's hands; tears, but her voice stays steady.*
E1-A1-03-2	**Yay Mey**	You did not come for your mother's memorial. Three years, Sora.	*Quiet reproach, not anger.*
E1-A1-03-3	**Sora**	I know, Yay. I'm here now.	
E1-A1-04-1	**Vuthy**	Cousin. It's been a long time.	*A small formal bow; doesn't look at the coffin.*
E1-A1-04-2	**Vuthy**	Grandmother hasn't slept in two days. All this incense and thread… it's what the old people need, I suppose.	*Low, so Yay Mey won't hear.*
E1-A1-04-3	**Vuthy**	I have to be at the office in town by seven. I'll come back at dawn. Don't let her frighten you with stories.	*Already turning to leave; relieved to go.*
E1-A1-05-1	**Yay Mey**	Tonight you keep his watch. I cannot. Three things.	*Formal, like a lesson.*
E1-A1-05-2	**Yay Mey**	Keep your lamp burning. A soul should not be left in the dark.	
E1-A1-05-3	**Yay Mey**	Keep the four incense sticks alight, one at each corner of him.	
E1-A1-05-4	**Yay Mey**	And the thread around the tent. It must not break. Whatever you hear.	*A pause before "whatever you hear".*
E1-A1-06-1	**Yay Mey**	One more thing. Make the betel offering for the ancestors. Do it as your mother used to. Her drawing is still by the altar.	*Softer at "your mother".*
E1-A1-07-1	**Sora**	Not his room. Not yet.	*On trying Sok's locked door.*
E1-A1-09-1	**Yay Mey**	Not like that. Look at her drawing again.	*Through her door, if the tray is wrong.*

ID	Speaker	Line	Direction
E1-A1-09-2	**Yay Mey**	Good. That is how she did it.	*Through her door, when correct. A long breath.*
E1-A1-09-3	**Yay Mey**	May our ancestors see this light and watch over the one who keeps it. The matches by the tray are blessed now. Keep them for when you need them most.	*The blessing must be checked with the advisor; it may be replaced by an appropriate traditional phrase.*

3.3 Act II

ID	Speaker	Line	Direction
E1-A2-01-1	**Sora**	…Yay?	*Footsteps above. No answer.*
E1-A2-05	**Sok**	See section 4, Sok's recording.	
E1-A2-09-1	**Sora**	No. No, no, no.	*Barely audible, seeing the portrait's eyes.*

3.4 Act III

ID	Speaker	Line	Direction
E1-A3-01-1	**Sora**	The thread—	*Sharp intake of breath at the snap.*
E1-A3-07-1	**Sora**	I give it back. Whatever he took, I give it back.	*Whispered over and over while lighting the burner, under the chant.*
E1-A3-07-2	**Presence**	…Sora.	*Directly behind, very close, almost gentle. Once only, at the midpoint of the ritual hold.*
E1-A3-07-C	**Chant**	Funeral chanting (smot), low and continuous.	*Recorded or licensed with permission; the text and its use approved by the advisor.*

3.5 Resolution

ID	Speaker	Line	Direction
E1-R02-1	**Vuthy**	Sora? You look… What happened here?	*Out of breath from the walk; sees the torn tent.*
E1-R02-2	**Vuthy**	Did my father leave anything? Papers, letters? Anything for me?	*Trying to sound casual; isn't.*
Choice A · Share the journal			
E1-R02-A1	**Sora**	He left this. You should read it.	*Hands him the journal.*
E1-R02-A2	**Vuthy**	…He believed all of it. Every word.	*After a long silence, turning pages.*

ID	Speaker	Line	Direction
E1-R02-A3	**Vuthy**	I need to think. I'll see to Grandmother.	*Keeps the journal a moment too long before handing it back.*
Choice B · Keep it			
E1-R02-B1	**Sora**	Old papers. Manuscripts. Nothing for you.	
E1-R02-B2	**Vuthy**	…Of course. Old papers. I'll see to Grandmother.	*He knows she is holding something back.*
E1-R03-1	**Sora**	…Me.	*Reading the slip. One word, almost no voice.*

04 Sok's Recording

Heard on the gramophone in beat A2-05, once the speed is corrected. About 55 seconds. Hoarse, urgent, close to the microphone, with gramophone crackle.

E1-A2-05 · UNCLE SOK · GRAMOPHONE RECORD

If this is playing, then I am dead, and you are the one keeping my vigil. Listen to me.

In 1910 my grandfather, Chea, made a bargain with the guardian of the land. Our lives, and a fortune, for a price: one of us from each generation. Four lives. Three have been paid. My father. My sister.

On the seventh night after my death, it will come to collect what is owed. Break the seals before then. There are five. The first is in my chest. Its key I gave to the water jars below the house. The key to my desk is where the ancestors keep watch.

I tried to begin. If you are hearing this, I failed. Forgive me. Forgive me for all of it.

Sok says "my sister" but never names who the fourth payment is. That silence is deliberate.

05 Sok's Journal (required pages)

JOURNAL PAGE A · BEHIND THE LOOSE PLANK (A2-03)

To whoever keeps my vigil.

My grandfather Chea went to the guardian's shrine in the forest in the famine year, with our family's silver betel box in his hands. The village was dying. His children were dying. He came home with the box full of earth and a promise.

We were saved. We were given land, and rice, and this house. And every so often the guardian comes for one of us. Grandfather first, within days. My father the next year. My sister, Kanha, in 1920, in the water, while I held her hand and could do nothing.

The pact is bound by five seals. Break all five, and the one who is named may end it. That is what the old men told me, and the monks, and the manuscripts. I believe them. I have to.

JOURNAL PAGE B · SOK'S DESK DRAWER (A2-07)

The first seal is the bronze token Grandfather wore. It is in the iron chest behind the planks of this room.

I broke the chest key into three and gave the pieces to the water jars beneath the house, where only family would look. Burn the token in the incense at the coffin, with matches blessed at our altar, before the third hour. Do not turn around while it burns. Whatever stands behind you, do not turn around.

Then the map. Then the pagoda. Then the rest. I am sorry it falls to you.

06 Lore Notes L1–L5

L1 · JOURNAL PAGE · HALL ALTAR DRAWER

Kanha used to make the betel tray for the ancestors every new moon. She drew it for the girl so she would learn. The girl never learned. She was twelve when we lost her mother, and Rith took her to the city, and that was that. I should have written to her more. I should have told her everything. I told her nothing.

L2 · JOURNAL PAGE · CLAY JAR J3, UNDER THE HOUSE

The clinic on the lake. I still dream of it. The water came up through the floor that night, as if something wanted her. I keep my medical logs from that year locked away. One day someone will need to know the date. The date matters.

L3 · JOURNAL PAGE · SOK'S WARDROBE

Vuthy was five when his mother died. He used to sit under this house and line up stones and tell me they were soldiers guarding us. I sent him to her family in town because I could not bear to look at him and count the years. He thinks I didn't love him. He is all I love.

L4 · LAND DEED · STORAGE SHED

Résidence de Battambang, March 1911. Certificate of concession: forty hectares of rice land granted to Monsieur Chhun, son of Chea, and his heirs. Stamped and signed. In the margin, in faded Khmer handwriting: "From nothing, in one year."

L5 · PHOTOGRAPH · STORAGE SHED

A woman laughing on these same front stairs, a small girl on her lap holding a pencil. On the back, in Rith's handwriting: "Kanha and Sora, Battambang, 1913. She drew the house today."

07 Story Objects

SOK'S SLIP OF NAMES · THE IRON CHEST (READ AT R03)

Chea — ~~crossed out~~
Chhun — ~~crossed out~~
Kanha — ~~crossed out~~
[a fourth name, scraped away until the paper is thin] — Sora

YAY MEY'S LETTERS · SORA'S SATCHEL (UNREAD)

A bundle of eleven envelopes tied with string, addressed in an old woman's careful hand to Sora's studio in Phnom Penh. Sora does not open them in Episode 1. They can be inspected but not read. Design note: Sora reads them at the end of Episode 5.

08 Sketchbook Entries

Short notes in Sora's handwriting beside small drawings. Written to be readable at a glance.

ID	Beat	Text	Drawing
SB-01	P05	(no text)	The illustration ruined by the ink blot
SB-02	A1-05	Keep the lamp burning. Keep the incense alight. Keep the thread whole.	Lamp, four incense sticks, a loop of thread
SB-03	A1-06	"As your mother used to." Her drawing is by the altar.	Rough copy of the altar
SB-03b	A1-08	Her tray, as she drew it.	Copy of Kanha's drawing: the round tray with its five offerings
SB-04	A2-03	1910. Great-grandfather Chea. A bargain. Four lives. Five seals.	Family names in a column
SB-05	A2-05	The seventh night after his death.	Seven empty circles; two filled lightly in pencil
SB-06	A2-07	Key in three pieces. The jars below.	The jars under the house
SB-07	A3-06	Before three. The burner. The blessed matches. Don't turn around.	The burner, a shadow behind a small figure
SB-08	R04	Four nights.	The third circle filled with ink wash

09 Translation and Review Notes

Item	Note
Forms of address	"Yay" (grandmother), "cousin", and how Vuthy and Sora address each other must use correct Khmer kinship terms and politeness levels.
Blessing (E1-A1-09-3)	Replace with an appropriate traditional phrase if the advisor prefers.
Chant (E1-A3-07-C)	Use real chanting only with permission and correct context; do not invent Pali.
French deed (L4)	Check the wording and format of a 1911 land concession.
Subtitles	Maximum two lines, about 42 characters per line in English; Khmer lines may need more time on screen.
Voice recording	Record each line three ways (normal, quieter, more emotional) to allow choice in editing.